The Crossover Sahiba

WHAT MAKES HER A SHERO

Last year saw Rashmika dominate both the box office with Sambhaji epic *Chhaava* and the indie scene, with a sensitive lead role in *The Girlfriend*



Photograph by **SAHIL BEHAL**; *Styled by* **ZUNAILI MALIK**

RASHMIKA MANDANNA, 30
Actress
Hyderabad

For long, Rashmika Mandanna was known for being the beguiling, bankable romantic interest in hero-centred blockbusters like the *Pushpa* films, *Animal* or *Chhaava*. Then came *The Girlfriend* (2025), a small, independent Telugu feature riding entirely on her shoulders. It's where audiences discovered the actress she truly is.

Playing a naïve collegian stuck in an emotionally abusive relationship and unable to express herself, Mandanna tapped into the anxiety and exhaustion of what it means to be with a domineering, toxic partner. "When you are in your early adulthood, you don't know that saying 'no' is okay. You always feel you have to be okay with what you get and this is how life is," says Mandanna. "A lot of us are not confident facing our fears and respecting what we feel."

It was a bold choice to pick as one's first solo vehicle but, for Mandanna, it was an "important story" that needed to be told and allowed her to explore her full range as a performer. "When you lead a film, there's a lot of room to dive into the layers and nuances of a character," she says.

One of the most prolific actresses in the industry, with five releases last year and across languages (Kannada, Hindi, Telugu, Tamil), Mandanna is currently recovering from a hip injury. "I feel this is the universe's way of saying you need rest. If you won't take a break, then we will break some tendon or something so that you have no option but to," she says with a laugh.

Recently married to actor Vijay Deverakonda, Mandanna actively strives to bring equilibrium between her personal and professional life. "I go on time for a shoot and don't bring work home after pack-up. I am very capable of disconnecting the two," she says. Looking back on her journey, which started with the Kannada hit *Kirik Party*, she is filled with a sense of contentment. "I have learned a lot about myself," she says. "I am the woman I wished to be a decade back. I have success, love and respect from peers and audience. I hope to continue doing so." ■

—Suhani Singh

HER TAKE

"Women should be financially independent before settling down with a partner of their choice. Take charge of your life. You have to work for respect, and happiness is a decision you have to make"